

VEER

Photos, Files, and Documents

Show it the thing instead of describing it.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Show it something rather than struggling to describe it in words.

Take a photo it can actually read, which is most of the battle.

Get a document summarised — and check the summary is honest.

Find the one line you need in something forty pages long.

Screenshot something confusing and get it explained.

Handle receipts, labels and handwriting, with realistic expectations.

Know what it can't do with a file, so you stop trying.

This is the first book in the series where you do something other than type. It's easier than it sounds.

01

Showing beats describing

There's a whole category of problem where you're stuck before you begin, because you can't describe the thing. You don't know what the part is called. You can't spell the word on the label. You'd have to type out four paragraphs of a letter to ask about one line of it.

Attaching it removes that problem entirely.

The move is always the same: attach the thing, then say what you want to know about it. Not "what is this" on its own — that gets you a description. Say what you're trying to work out.

THE SHAPE THAT WORKS

Here's a photo of a plant that's been going yellow for about two weeks. It's by a north-facing window and I water it weekly. What's likely to be wrong, and what should I try first?

Notice what's there besides the photo: how long, the conditions, what you've been doing. **The picture shows what a thing looks like. It can't show what's been happening to it.**

ATTACH, THEN ASK — IN THAT ORDER

Put the file in first and let it load, then type your question. Asking first and attaching second sometimes leaves the question answered before the picture arrived.

Try this now. Photograph something you've been meaning to ask about, attach it, and say what you want to know.

02

A photo it can actually read

Most disappointing answers about a photo are a photo problem, not an understanding problem. It can only work with what's visible, and it will make its best guess at anything that isn't — confidently.

Four things fix nearly every bad photo:

Light. Daylight or a lamp, not the shadow of your own head. This is the biggest one by far.

Straight on. Photograph a document flat from above, not at an angle from a chair.

Close, then closer. Fill the frame with the thing. A tiny label in a big kitchen is unreadable.

Still. Rest your elbows on something. Blur destroys small text.

For anything with text on it, take two photos: one of the whole object so it knows what it's looking at, and one close-up of the text.

Check it can read it before you rely on it.

THE VERIFICATION STEP

Before you answer, read back to me exactly what the text in this image says. If any of it is unclear, tell me which part rather than guessing.

That single ask prevents the worst failure in this book — a confident answer built on a misread word. Use it whenever the answer matters.

IT WILL GUESS AT WHAT IT CAN'T SEE

A blurred digit, a word in shadow, a cut-off line — none of these produce an error message. They produce a plausible-looking answer. Ask it to read back, or retake the photo.

Try this now. Photograph something with small print. Ask it to read the text back before answering.

03

A document, summarised honestly

Attaching a long document and asking what it says is one of the genuinely transformative uses. It's also where a bad summary is hardest to notice, because you haven't read the thing.

Ask for structure, not a paragraph.

BETTER THAN "SUMMARISE THIS"

Here's a twelve-page report. Give me: what it's about in two sentences, the main points as a short list, anything it recommends, and anything that struck you as unusual or unclear.

Four separate jobs. You can check each one.

Then check the summary against the document.

THE HONESTY CHECK

For each point in that summary, tell me roughly where in the document it came from, and quote the sentence it's based on.

If it can't point at a source, that point may not be in there. This is the single most useful habit in this lesson.

Ask what it left out. *What's in this document that didn't make your summary, and why?* Sometimes the omission is the thing you needed.

Try this now. Summarise something you *have* read. See how it does when you can mark its work.

04

Finding the one thing you need

Often you don't want a summary. You want one fact out of forty pages, and you don't want to read thirty-nine of them.

THE NEEDLE

Here's the tenancy agreement. Find everything it says about giving notice — how much, in what form, and to whom. Quote the actual wording and tell me which section it's in.

"Quote the actual wording" is the instruction that matters. A paraphrase of a contract clause is not the clause, and for anything you'll act on you want the words themselves.

Ask it to say when something isn't there.

ADD THIS TO ANY SEARCH

If the document doesn't cover this, say so plainly rather than telling me what documents like this usually say.

Without that, a missing clause can quietly become a described one. This is worth adding every time.

Ask for everything, then narrow. *Find every mention of pets* first, then read. Better than asking a specific question that misses a clause worded differently.

Try this now. Take a long document and find one thing. Ask for the exact wording.

05

Screenshotting something confusing

The most underused move in this book, especially on a phone.

An error message. A form that won't submit. A menu you can't find your way out of. A bank statement line you don't recognise. A settings screen full of options nobody explained.

Screenshot it, attach it, and ask what you're looking at.

THE ONE EVERYONE SHOULD KNOW

This message keeps appearing when I try to send an email. I don't understand what it's telling me. What does it mean and what should I do about it?

This works because error messages are written by engineers for engineers, and translating them is exactly the kind of task this is good at.

It also works for "where is the thing". Screenshot the screen you're stuck on and ask where the option you're looking for lives.

SCREENSHOTS HOLD MORE THAN YOU THINK

A screenshot of an email shows your address, the sender, and whatever else was on screen. A bank app screenshot shows your balance. Crop before you attach, and see [Is This Safe?](#) for the fuller version.

Try this now. Next time something on a screen confuses you, screenshot it instead of squinting.

06

Receipts, labels, and handwriting

Realistic expectations, because this is where results vary most.

Printed text on a flat surface — very reliable. Receipts, labels, packaging, printed letters.

Faded or crumpled receipts — variable. Worth trying, worth checking.

Neat handwriting — often good. **Your grandmother's letters** — sometimes remarkable, sometimes wrong, and you won't always be able to tell which.

Old documents, unusual scripts, cramped forms — treat anything it returns as a first attempt to be checked against the original.

Always ask it to read back before interpreting, exactly as in Lesson 2. With handwriting this stops being a nicety and becomes the whole method.

FOR ANYTHING HANDWRITTEN

Transcribe this as accurately as you can. Mark anything you're unsure about with a question mark rather than guessing at it, and tell me which words those are.

A GENUINELY LOVELY USE

Transcribing old family letters, recipe cards in a relative's handwriting, or the back of photographs. Slow, occasionally wrong, and often the only realistic way anyone will ever type them up. Check the names and dates yourself.

Try this now. Find something handwritten in your house and ask for a transcription with the uncertain words marked.

07

Several things at once

Comparing documents is where this saves the most time, because doing it by hand means holding both in your head.

THE COMPARISON

Here are two quotes for the same job. Put them side by side, tell me what's in one and not the other, and list anything neither of them covers.

ACROSS A SET

Here are six months of statements from the same account. Tell me what changed over that period and flag anything that looks out of pattern.

Attach them together in one message where you can, rather than one after another, so it's comparing rather than remembering.

Name them. *The first one is from Baxter, the second from Hollis* makes the answer readable.

Ask it to be explicit about what it can't compare. Two documents in different formats sometimes aren't answering the same question at all, and that's worth knowing.

CHECK THE NUMBERS YOURSELF

Arithmetic across documents is exactly the sort of task where a confident wrong answer is easy to produce and hard to spot. Use it to see the shape of the difference, then check the figures that matter.

Try this now. Compare two things you've been meaning to compare.

08

What it can't do with a file

Knowing the limits stops you wasting an afternoon.

It doesn't change the file on your computer. It works from a copy you handed over. Anything it produces comes back as text or a new document for you to save — your original is untouched.

It doesn't keep the file. Start a new conversation and it has no memory of what you attached before. Attach it again.

It can't tell you a document is genuine. It can say a letter reads oddly for its type. It cannot tell you whether it's real, and a convincing forgery reads as convincing.

It can't see what isn't in the picture. The cut-off edge, the second page you didn't photograph, the reverse of the sheet.

It isn't a filing system. It's excellent at reading one thing or comparing a few; it isn't where your documents should live.

And it can be wrong about what it read. Everything from *Is This Safe?* applies with more force here, because a misread word looks exactly like a read one.

THE HABIT THAT COVERS MOST OF THIS

For anything that matters: ask it to read back what it sees, ask it to quote rather than paraphrase, and check the numbers yourself. Three small habits, and they catch nearly everything.

Try this now. Re-read that list and notice which one you were about to try anyway.

Before you attach anything

Six checks, in order. Most take a second.

Crop or cover anything private. Account numbers, addresses, other people's names, whatever else was on the screen.

Check it's legible to you at the size you're sending it. If you can't read it, neither can it.

Good light, straight on, filling the frame. Two photos for anything with small print: the whole thing, then the text.

Say what you want to know — not "what is this", but what you're trying to work out.

Ask it to read back anything where a misread word would matter.

Ask it to quote, not paraphrase, for anything you'll act on.

Current as of Q3 2026

The only page tied to things that change. Check you have the current edition.

How to attach. Look for an attach or upload control near the box where you type — usually a paperclip or plus symbol. On a phone you'll normally be offered your camera as well as your photo library, so you can photograph something without leaving the conversation.

What you can attach. Images and common document formats are supported, and the range has grown over time. If something won't upload, a screenshot or a photograph of it usually will.

Limits. There are limits on file size and on how many things you can attach at once, and they differ between free and paid plans. They also change. If an upload is refused, that's usually why — try one file at a time, or a smaller version.

VERIFY BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

Supported formats, size limits and how many files you can attach change regularly, and they vary by plan. Check the official source rather than a printed page — including this one.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other seven.

Ask it to read the thing back to you before it answers.

Before you answer, read back exactly what the text says, and tell me which parts are unclear rather than guessing.

Every serious failure in this book is the same failure: it misread a word, didn't say so, and built a confident answer on top. A blurred digit in an account number, a misread date on a letter, a cut-off line in a contract — none of them announce themselves.

One sentence catches nearly all of it. Use it any time the answer matters.

Do this next

Attaching letters, bills and contracts? → Paperwork and Plain English — the three-ask pass, and the seven signs it's time to pay for advice instead.

Worried about what's in the picture? → Is This Safe? — what it can and can't see, and the four things never to hand over. Read it before you photograph anything with your details on it.

Want it to stop asking who you are every time? → Making Claude Remember You — set your situation once instead of re-explaining.

Doing this on a phone? → Claude on Your Phone — where photographing things on the spot genuinely comes into its own.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

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